

24STCV03817 24STCV03817

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Case Number: 24STCV03817 Hearing Date: July 20, 2026 Dept: 732

Tatiana Davis, et al. v. San Joaquin Valley College,
Inc., et al.

Monday, July 20, 2026

CASE NUMBER: 24STCV03817

OPPOSED

Plaintiffs

Tatiana Davis, Angela Howard, Abigail Inostroza, Sydney Kline, Natasha

Lee,

Vanessa Reed, Maria Saucedo, Katerina Simmons, Talitha Hooks, and Amanda
Dominguez's Motions to Compel

Further Responses to Deposition Questions from Defendant Trevor Doyle

Facts: This is an

action for sexual harassment and discrimination. The First Amended Complaint (FAC) alleges as follows. Plaintiffs are made up of members of two cohorts of students at Defendant San Joaquin Valley College, Inc. (College) who attended a class led by Defendant Trevor Doyle (Doyle). (FAC ¶¶ 20, 27.) During their time in Doyle's class, he made numerous inappropriate sexual remarks and advances toward Plaintiffs, and inappropriately touched or groped Plaintiffs. (FAC ¶¶ 20–21, 28–29.) Despite Plaintiffs' complaints about Doyle's conduct, College

failed to discipline Doyle, allowing him to retaliate against Plaintiffs by giving them artificially reduced grades. (FAC ¶¶ 25, 30.)

Procedural History: Plaintiffs filed the original Complaint on February 14, 2024, and filed the FAC on March 26, 2024, alleging seven causes of action:

1.

Sexual Harassment (Civ. Code § 51.9)

2.

Sexual Battery (Civ. Code § 1708.5)

3.

Sexual Assault

4.

Negligence

5.

Intentional Infliction of Emotional Distress

6.

Negligent Hiring, Supervision, and Retention

7.

Sex Discrimination

On September 9, 2024, this court sustained with leave to amend Defendant Trevor Doyle's demurrer to the second cause of action for sexual battery asserted by Plaintiff Talitha Hooks, and as to the fifth cause of action for intentional infliction of emotional distress.

On October 15, 2025, this court denied Plaintiff Natasha Lee's motion to quash deposition subpoena to Caleb Bragg.

On December 18, 2025, this court granted in part Plaintiff Tatiyana Davis's motion to compel further

responses to requests for production from Defendant Trevor Doyle.

On January 8, 2026, this court granted in part Plaintiffs Angela Howard, Abigail Inostroza, and Sydney Kline's motions to compel further responses to requests for production from Defendant Doyle.

On January 21, 2026, this court granted Defendant Doyle's motion to quash subpoena.

On April 2, 2026, this court granted in part Plaintiffs' motion to compel further responses to requests for production from Defendant San Joaquin Valley College.

This court on July 9, 2026, this court granted Defendant San Joaquin Valley College's motion to compel compliance with subpoenas to Jennifer Kristen Brady and Erica Robinson.

Plaintiffs filed the present motion to compel further deposition testimony from Defendant Trevor Doyle on January 15, 2026.

Doyle filed an opposition on July 7, 2026.

Plaintiffs filed a reply on July 13, 2026.

Analysis

I.

MOTION TO COMPEL DEPOSITION ANSWERS

"If a deponent fails to answer any question or to produce any document, electronically stored information, or tangible thing under the deponent's control that is specified in the deposition notice or a deposition subpoena, the party seeking discovery may move the court for an order compelling that answer or production." (Code Civ. Proc. § 2025.480, subd. (a)).

With certain exceptions, “deposition examination of the witness by all counsel, other than the witness’ counsel of record, shall be limited to seven hours of total testimony. The court shall allow additional time, beyond any limits imposed by this section, if needed to fairly examine the deponent or if the deponent, another person, or any other circumstance impedes or delays the examination.” (Code Civ. Proc. § 2025.290, subd. (a).)

Plaintiffs

Tatiana Davis, Angela Howard, Abigail Inostroza, Sydney Kline, Natasha Lee, Vanessa Reed, Maria Saucedo, Katerina Simmons, Talitha Hooks, and Amanda Dominguez (“Plaintiffs”) move to compel further deposition answers from Defendant Trevor Doyle (“Doyle”), and to resume his deposition following a full seven hours of testimony. Plaintiffs argue that Doyle, on counsel’s instruction, refused to answer questions about his knowledge of bondage equipment depicted in an image alleged to have been sent by him to one of the Plaintiffs, and further refused to confirm his telephone number, on grounds of privacy. (See Separate Statement.) Plaintiffs argue that as their claims sound in sexual harassment allegedly perpetrated by Doyle, and that there are ten Plaintiffs in this action, additional deposition time is required beyond the customary seven-hour limit. (Motion at pp. 5–8.)

Defendant Doyle argues that

Plaintiffs failed to adequately meet and confer before bringing the present motion. (Opposition at pp. 12–13.) The record reflects that, after Doyle’s deposition on May 14, 2025, Plaintiffs’ counsel followed up with an email seeking additional time and addressing Doyle’s refusal to answer certain questions on May 28, 2025. (Hames Decl. Exh. 4.) The parties conferred regarding an extension of time for deposition through August 2025. (Ibid.) On October 15, 2025, Plaintiffs’ counsel sent another email indicating that additional time was needed for deposition given the number of plaintiffs, and proposed several dates. (Hames Decl. Exh. 5.) The parties had a teleconference on an extension of time for Doyle’s deposition on November 10, 2025, which did not result in resolution, and further emails were exchanged through December 10, 2025. (Hames Decl. Exh. 6.) On December 30, 2025, Plaintiffs’ counsel sent an email specifically stating the questions that Doyle failed to answer for which they sought a further response, to which Doyle’s counsel responded on January 8, 2026, that no further response was needed, and that they would stand by their objections. (Ibid.) These efforts were adequate prelude to the motion, filed on January 15, 2026.

The questions at issue are these. Doyle was shown a photograph allegedly sent by him to one of the Plaintiffs, depicting bondage equipment laid out on a table. (Hames Decl. Exh. 3.) Asked if he had ever seen the items depicted before, Doyle responded, "Yes, I've seen items such as these before." (Separate Statement at p. 2.) He was asked, "[W]hat was the context of that?" (Ibid.) Whereupon Doyle's counsel objected on privacy grounds and instructed him not to answer. (Ibid.) The same instruction was given for the questions, "Is anything depicted in the picture yours?" and "Do you know what the objects depicted in the picture are?" (Separate Statement at pp. 2–3.)

Doyle was later asked, "During the time you were employed at SJVC, what was your phone number?" (Separate Statement at p. 3.) A privacy objection was raised, and he was instructed not to answer. (Ibid.) He was later asked concerning a specific number, "is that still your phone number?" and whether it was his phone number "as of October 14, 2021." (Id. at pp. 3–4.) He was again instructed not to answer. (Id. at pp. 3–4.)

Deponents should generally "not be prevented by counsel from answering a question unless it pertains to privileged matters or deposing counsel's conduct has reached a stage where suspension is warranted." (*Stewart v. Colonial Western Agency, Inc.* (2001) 87 Cal.App.4th 1006, 1015.) "It is generally improper . . . for counsel to instruct a witness not to answer on grounds other than privilege, privacy, trade secrets or other matters statutorily or constitutionally exempt from discovery." (Weil & Brown, *Civil Procedure Before Trial* (The Rutter Group 2023) Ch. 8E-12 [8:695].)

Doyle raises arguments concerning the privacy of his sexual associations and his contact information. "In determining whether disclosure is required [against a privacy objection], the court must indulge in a 'careful balancing' of the right of a civil litigant to discover relevant facts, on the one hand, and the right of the third parties to maintain reasonable privacy regarding their sensitive personal affairs, on the other. The court must consider the purpose of the information sought, the effect that disclosure will have on the affected persons and parties, the nature of the objections urged by the party resisting disclosure and availability of alternative, less intrusive means for obtaining the requested information. Based on an application of these factors, the more

sensitive the nature of the personal information that is sought to be discovered, the more substantial the showing of the need for the discovery that will be required before disclosure will be permitted." (Hooser v. Superior Court (2000) 84 Cal.App.4th 997, 1004, internal citations omitted.)

Further

responses are required. The questions related to the items in the picture are not freewheeling inquiries into Doyle's sexual conduct, but direct questions concerning his knowledge of items in a particular photograph allegedly sent by him. He may be asked such questions, as this is a sexual harassment case in which such messages and photos constitute evidence of harassing conduct. The questions at issue relate directly to Doyle's personal knowledge of the items depicted in the photograph, which he denies sending, and are therefore relevant to determine the origins of the message and photograph.

Additionally,

Doyle may be compelled to answer questions concerning his phone number. Although his counsel objected that he may be contacted through counsel, said number is relevant not so Doyle may be contacted, but to authenticate text messages and other communications allegedly had with Plaintiffs. Doyle in opposition objects that Plaintiffs intend to subpoena his phone records, which they cannot do for a variety of reasons. (Opposition at pp. 9–12.) But this motion does not concern any such subpoena. Even absent a subpoena for phone records, the number is relevant to authenticate communications already in the possession of the parties. And while Defendant argues that teacher's personal contact information normally ought not to be disclosed to students, Plaintiffs do not come to this court seeking Doyle's contact information for their amusement, but because they and Doyle are civil litigants in a case in which Doyle is alleged to have sexually harassed his students. The information sought is directly relevant to these proceedings, and the contemplated privacy intrusion is minimal. Should Doyle have reason to fear harassment or other annoyance from disclosure, he may avail himself of the protective order already entered in this case. (See 1/15/2025 Protective Order.)

Plaintiffs

also show good cause for additional time for Doyle's deposition. This is a sexual harassment case involving ten plaintiffs, each of whom alleges harassment in some form by Doyle. It is therefore reasonable and foreseeable that his deposition should exceed the ordinary seven-hour limit, in order to

address each Plaintiff's allegations and corresponding evidence. Although Plaintiffs seek an additional two days of deposition, in meet-and-confer correspondence they offered one additional day, while Doyle sought to limit any further deposition to four hours, to be taken up largely by the questioning of co-defendant San Joaquin Valley College. (Motion at pp. 9–10; Hames Decl. Exhs. 4–6.) A single additional deposition day, not to exceed seven hours, is proper under the present circumstances.

Accordingly, the motion to compel is GRANTED. Doyle's shall answer questions related to his personal knowledge of objects in the photo attached as Exhibit 3 to the Hames declaration, and answer questions concerning his phone numbers. Pursuant to Code Civ. Proc. § 2025.290, Defendant Doyle is directed to appear for an additional seven hours of deposition.

1.

Sanctions

"The court shall impose a monetary sanction under Chapter 7 (commencing with Section 2023.010) against any party, person, or attorney who unsuccessfully makes or opposes a motion to compel an answer or production, unless it finds that the one subject to the sanction acted with substantial justification or that other circumstances make the imposition of the sanction unjust." (Code Civ. Proc. § 2025.480, subd. (j).)

Plaintiffs

seek \$5,962.50 in sanctions against Doyle and his counsel, representing 7.5 hours of attorney work at \$725 per hour. (Hames Decl. ¶ 6.) Doyle in turn seeks sanctions in the amount of \$2,925.00. (Mullane Decl. ¶ 13.) Sanctions are proper against Doyle and his counsel in the amount of \$3,625.00, representing five hours of attorney work, excluding meet and confer efforts which ought to have been undertaken in any event.

Sanctions

are awarded against Doyle and his counsel in the amount of \$3,625.00.

Superior Court of California

County of Los Angeles

Department 732

TATIYANA
DAVIS, et al.

Plaintiffs

v.

SAN JOAQUIN VALLEY COLLEGE, INC.,
et al.,

Defendants.

Case No.:
24STCV03817

Hearing Date: July 20, 2026

[TENTATIVE] RULING RE:

Plaintiffs Tatiyana Davis, Angela Howard, Abigail
Inostroza, Sydney Kline, Natasha

Lee,
Vanessa Reed, Maria Saucedo, Katerina Simmons, Talitha Hooks, and Amanda
Dominguez's Motions to Compel Further Responses to Deposition Questions from
Defendant Trevor Doyle

Plaintiffs Tatiyana Davis, Angela Howard,
Abigail Inostroza, Sydney Kline, Natasha

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Maria Saucedo, Katerina Simmons, Talitha Hooks, and Amanda Dominguez's Motions
to Compel Further Responses to Deposition Questions from Defendant Trevor Doyle
are

GRANTED. Defendant Doyle is directed to answer questions related to his
personal knowledge of objects in the photo, and to answer questions concerning
his phone numbers. Pursuant to Code Civ. Proc. § 2025.290, Defendant
Doyle is directed to appear for an additional seven hours of deposition.

Sanctions

are awarded against Doyle and his counsel in the amount of \$3,625.00.

Plaintiff to give notice.

Dated: July 20, 2026

Hon.

Richard S. Kemalyan

Judge

of the Superior Court